

OKR & KPI VALUE FRAMEWORK

FOR ENTERPRISE ARCHITECTS

A comprehensive research report examining the distinctions between OKRs and KPIs, their strategic value, and the critical metrics that Enterprise Architects must track to demonstrate business impact and drive organisational alignment.

STRATEGY

GOVERNANCE

PERFORMANCE

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SECTION 1

Understanding OKRs — Objectives & Key Results

OKRs (Objectives and Key Results) are a strategic goal-setting framework designed to connect ambitious organisational aspirations with measurable outcomes. Popularised by John Doerr in his book *Measure What Matters*, and adopted by companies like Google, Intel, and LinkedIn, OKRs operate at the intersection of vision and execution.

Core Components

Each OKR consists of two parts: an **Objective** — a short, qualitative, inspirational description of what you want to achieve — and **Key Results** — 2 to 4 specific, quantitative metrics that indicate progress toward that objective. OKRs encourage stretch goals that are intentionally ambitious, typically aiming for 70–80% completion rather than 100%.

Key Characteristics of OKRs

Time-bound	Typically set on monthly or quarterly cycles to maintain agility.
Ambitious	OKRs encourage stretch goals that challenge teams beyond comfortable targets.
Transparent	Published organisation-wide to align all teams around shared priorities.
Outcome-focused	Prioritise results and change over tasks and activities.
Cascading	Flow from company to department to individual, ensuring alignment.

When to Use OKRs

OKRs are most effective when organisations need to drive significant change or transformation, set ambitious stretch goals, align all levels of the organisation around key strategic priorities, or focus efforts on achieving breakthroughs in critical areas. Unlike KPIs, OKRs are not suited for monitoring business-as-usual operations — they are instruments of directed progress.

"OKRs are your destination and strategic route — they describe where you are going and the milestones that prove you are getting there."

SECTION 2

Understanding KPIs — Key Performance Indicators

Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) are specific, quantifiable metrics used to evaluate the success of an organisation, department, project, or individual in meeting defined performance objectives. While OKRs describe where you are going, KPIs are the gauges on your dashboard telling you how the engine is running right now.

Types of KPIs

Lagging KPIs	Measure outcomes that have already occurred (e.g., annual revenue, customer churn rate). They confirm trends but cannot change past results.
Leading KPIs	Predictive measures that indicate future performance (e.g., pipeline value, employee engagement scores). Actionable and forward-looking.
Operational KPIs	Short-term metrics measuring daily or weekly activity efficiency (e.g., deployment frequency, incident resolution time).
Strategic KPIs	Long-term indicators aligned to corporate goals (e.g., market share growth, digital revenue percentage).

SMART Criteria for Effective KPIs

Good KPIs follow the SMART framework — they must be **Specific** (clearly defined and unambiguous), **Measurable** (quantifiable with reliable data), **Achievable** (realistic given current capabilities), **Relevant** (aligned to strategic priorities), and **Time-bound** (tied to a reporting period). KPIs that fail these criteria often lead to measurement for its own sake rather than genuine performance insight.

When to Use KPIs

KPIs are most appropriate when organisations need to monitor ongoing operational performance and business health, measure the efficiency and effectiveness of existing processes, track incremental improvements against established targets, or ensure stability and consistency in core functions such as finance, operations, and customer service.

SECTION 3

OKR vs KPI — Core Differences & Synergies

A common misconception is that OKRs and KPIs are competing frameworks. In reality, they are complementary instruments that operate at different levels of an organisation's performance management system. An OKR is a strategic framework; a KPI is a metric that exists within a framework. KPIs most often monitor the steady-state, while OKRs describe the outcomes — the intended results of actions taken on those KPIs.

Comparison Matrix

Dimension	OKR	KPI
Primary Purpose	Drive ambitious change & transformation	Monitor ongoing performance & health
Time Horizon	Quarterly / annual cycles	Continuous / ongoing tracking
Nature	Qualitative objective + quantitative results	Purely quantitative metric
Ambition Level	Stretch goals (70-80% achievement is success)	Achievable targets (100% is expected)
Scope	Organisational, team, and individual alignment	Process, project, or departmental
Flexibility	Recalibrated every cycle	Stable over longer periods
Best Use	Strategic transformation programmes	Operational dashboards & reporting
Ownership	Cross-functional teams / individuals	Department / function owners

How They Work Together

The most successful organisations leverage both frameworks as part of a comprehensive performance management system. A KPI might reveal that customer satisfaction scores are declining — this insight then triggers an OKR to address root causes and drive improvement. By integrating OKRs, organisations can elevate KPIs from simple measurements to powerful tools that achieve strategic goals. The hierarchy flows: strategy defines OKRs, OKRs identify the most critical KPIs to move, and KPI tracking provides the data that informs OKR progress reviews.

SECTION 4

The Role of the Enterprise Architect

The Enterprise Architect (EA) sits at the intersection of business strategy, technology direction, and organisational change. The EA translates high-level corporate ambitions into actionable technology roadmaps, governance frameworks, and architectural standards that guide an organisation's evolution over time.

Why EA Measurement Is Uniquely Challenging

Unlike delivery teams where progress is easily measured in tasks completed or features shipped, the EA operates primarily in the domain of outcomes. These outcomes are multi-dimensional, interdependent, and influenced by forces beyond the architect's direct span of control. Traditional HR-driven performance frameworks often do not reflect this strategic complexity. Many goal-setting approaches value short-term deliverables and activity metrics, which can unintentionally push Enterprise Architects toward documenting rather than enabling change.

Two Levels of EA Value

OUTPUTS	Tangible deliverables within direct EA control: Architecture roadmaps, reference architectures, technology standards, capability models, governance frameworks, steering forums, and architecture decision records (ADRs).
OUTCOMES	Organisational movement enabled by those outputs: Reduced technology fragmentation, accelerated product integration, improved stakeholder alignment, faster innovation cycles, lower total cost of ownership, and increased architectural maturity scores.

The Enterprise Architect's value is not measured in the number of documents produced but in how the organisation moves more coherently, more efficiently, and with greater strategic intent as a result of their work. Goals and KPIs for EAs should be treated as a framework for structured discussion rather than a rigid scorecard.

SECTION 5

Strategic KPIs Every Enterprise Architect Should Track

Enterprise architecture metrics are a set of predetermined ways architects and stakeholders measure the success of EA. They track how enterprise architecture and its strategy affect the alignment, agility, and effectiveness of business. Below are the five critical domains with their associated KPIs.

1. Strategic Alignment

Measures how effectively the technology landscape supports corporate strategy.

KPI Name	Description	Target / Benchmark
Strategic Goal Alignment %	% of technology projects directly supporting strategic objectives	Target: >80%
Business Capability Coverage	% of core business capabilities supported by current IT stack	Target: >90%
EA Engagement in Strategy	Frequency of EA involvement in business strategy sessions	Monthly min.
Architecture Adoption Rate	% of new projects following approved architecture patterns	Target: >85%

2. Cost & Financial Value

Quantifies the financial contribution and efficiency of architecture decisions.

KPI Name	Description	Target / Benchmark
Total Cost of Ownership (TCO)	Aggregate cost of developing, improving, and maintaining capabilities	Year-on-year delta
Application Rationalisation Savings	Cost savings from retiring, consolidating, or renegotiating applications	\$ saved per cycle
Project ROI	$\frac{[(\text{Financial Gain} - \text{Cost of Investment}) / \text{Cost of Investment}]}{x 100}$	Target: >15%
Technology Debt Reduction	% reduction in identified technical debt items per quarter	Target: >10%/quarter

3. Agility & Time to Market

Tracks the speed at which the organisation can respond to change.

KPI Name	Description	Target / Benchmark
Time to Market	Speed from ideation to production deployment for new capabilities	Trend: decreasing
Integration Cycle Time	Average time to integrate new systems with the existing landscape	Benchmark vs prior

Architecture Review Cycle	Average time to complete an architecture review for new proposals	Target: <2 weeks
Deployment Frequency	How often new architecture-compliant releases are deployed to production	Trend: increasing

4. Risk & Compliance

Monitors architectural risk exposure and regulatory compliance posture.

KPI Name	Description	Target / Benchmark
Risks Discovered vs Incidents	Ratio of architecture risks identified proactively vs reactive incidents	Higher ratio = better
Compliance with Standards	% of business applications compliant with IT architecture standards	Target: >95%
Security Architecture Debt	Number of open security architecture findings by severity	Critical = 0
End-of-Life Technology %	% of estate running on unsupported or EOL platforms	Target: <5%

5. Stakeholder & Business Value

Gauges trust, adoption, and perceived value of EA across the organisation.

KPI Name	Description	Target / Benchmark
Stakeholder Satisfaction (NPS)	Net Promoter Score from business leaders and end-users on EA services	Target: >50
Architecture Pattern Adoption	% of teams proactively using recommended patterns without mandate	Trend: increasing
EA Influence Index	Weighted score of EA input accepted vs overridden in steering decisions	Target: >70%
Capability Maturity Score	Average maturity score across key business capabilities assessed	Target: Level 3+

SECTION 6

OKR Examples for Enterprise Architecture Teams

OKRs provide a natural structure for enterprise architecture measurement by connecting aspirational objectives to measurable key results. Below are four practical OKR sets that EA teams can adopt and adapt to their organisational context.

O1: Reduce technology fragmentation and redundancy across the estate

KR1: Decommission or consolidate 25% of identified duplicate applications within 6 months

KR2: Reduce the number of active technology platforms from 47 to 32 by Q4

KR3: Achieve TCO reduction of 18% on rationalised application portfolio

KR4: Increase architecture adoption rate from 62% to 85% for new projects

O2: Establish EA as a trusted strategic partner to business leadership

KR1: Improve stakeholder NPS from 35 to 55 by end of year

KR2: Achieve EA involvement in 100% of major strategic planning sessions

KR3: Reduce architecture review cycle time from 4 weeks to 10 business days

KR4: Increase % of EA recommendations accepted from 58% to 78%

O3: Accelerate innovation by improving integration speed and agility

KR1: Reduce average integration cycle time from 14 weeks to 6 weeks

KR2: Decrease time to market for new digital capabilities by 40%

KR3: Achieve 90% of new integrations using approved API-first patterns

KR4: Reduce production incidents caused by integration failures by 60%

O4: Elevate organisational capability maturity to support future growth

KR1: Move average capability maturity score from Level 2 to Level 3 across 8 key domains

KR2: Complete architecture roadmaps for all Tier-1 business capabilities

KR3: Train and certify 75% of solution architects on updated EA standards

KR4: Reduce end-of-life technology percentage from 12% to below 5%

SECTION 7

Connecting EA Metrics to Business Value

Enterprise architects must demonstrate value across three key stakeholder dimensions: Customer Value, Shareholder Value, and Risk Reduction. Each dimension requires both direct EA metrics and business-outcome indicators.

Stakeholder	Business Metric	EA-Attributed Contribution	Measurement
Customer	Net Promoter Score (NPS)	Faster feature delivery, improved reliability	Survey + incident rate
Customer	Digital Experience Quality	API standardisation & integration patterns	Page load, error rate
Shareholder	Revenue per Technology Dollar	Rationalised portfolio, reduced TCO	Revenue / IT spend ratio
Shareholder	Innovation Rate	Reusable platforms enabling faster launches	New products / year
Risk	Cybersecurity Posture	Security architecture standards & controls	Vulnerabilities open / closed
Risk	Regulatory Compliance	Architecture governance frameworks	Audit findings / year
Risk	Business Continuity	Resilience architecture & DR patterns	RTO / RPO achievement %

The Attribution Challenge

A critical honest observation from practitioners is that it is often difficult to directly attribute changes in business KPIs to Enterprise Architecture specifically. EA operates as an enabling function — its influence is systemic and collaborative rather than direct. This is why EA teams should maintain both direct activity metrics (architecture reviews completed, standards adopted) and outcome linkage metrics (business capability improvement scores, integration cycle improvements) to build a credible narrative of value over time.

SECTION 8

Implementation Roadmap & Best Practices

Recommended Implementation Phases

Phase 1 Foundation (Months 1-2)	• Inventory current EA outputs and existing metrics • Identify key stakeholders and their value expectations • Establish data sources for baseline KPI measurement • Define measurement frequency and reporting calendar
Phase 2 Alignment (Months 3-4)	• Map EA outputs to strategic organisational OKRs • Select 5-7 headline KPIs for executive dashboard • Define operational KPIs for Architecture Review Board • Launch first quarterly OKR cycle for EA team
Phase 3 Execution (Months 5-8)	• Implement tracking tooling and reporting cadence • Conduct monthly stakeholder briefings on EA metrics • Run first full OKR review cycle with retrospective • Expand dashboard to include predictive / leading KPIs
Phase 4 Optimise (Months 9-12)	• Recalibrate OKRs and KPIs based on first-year learnings • Introduce capability maturity assessments as ongoing KPI • Build attribution models linking EA work to business outcomes • Integrate EA metrics into corporate performance management

Best Practices

Align to Strategic Themes	Define EA goals around strategic themes (customer experience, operational resilience, innovation readiness, cost efficiency) rather than fixed projects. Themes remain relevant even when individual initiatives change.
Review Quarterly, Not Annually	Goals and KPIs should be recalibrated quarterly to reflect evolving priorities. Annual reviews are too infrequent given the pace of organisational change.
Progressive Disclosure Dashboards	Apply the principle of progressive disclosure: executive dashboards show 5-7 headline metrics with drill-down paths, while operational dashboards display real-time system state for Architecture Review Boards.
Influence as a Valid Metric	A key indicator of EA success is whether stakeholders trust architectural direction and whether teams adopt recommended patterns proactively rather than reactively.
Combine OKRs and KPIs	Use OKRs to define where the architecture function is heading each quarter, and KPIs to monitor the steady-state health metrics that underpin that journey.

SECTION 9

Summary & Key Takeaways

This report has examined the theoretical foundations and practical applications of OKRs and KPIs within the context of Enterprise Architecture. The following key takeaways summarise the essential insights for practitioners.

1	OKRs and KPIs are not competing — they are complementary. OKRs define direction and ambition; KPIs measure the ongoing health of the journey.
2	Enterprise Architects must measure at two levels: outputs (deliverables in their control) and outcomes (organisational improvements their work enables).
3	The five critical KPI domains for EA are: Strategic Alignment, Cost & Financial Value, Agility & Time to Market, Risk & Compliance, and Stakeholder Value.
4	EA value maps to three stakeholder dimensions: Customer Value (NPS, experience), Shareholder Value (TCO, innovation rate), and Risk Reduction (compliance, continuity).
5	OKRs for EA should be quarterly, ambitious, and cascaded — connecting the architecture function's objectives to the organisation's strategic themes.
6	The attribution challenge is real. EA operates as an enabling function; build a dual narrative of direct activity metrics and outcome linkage indicators.
7	Effective measurement is a conversation, not a scorecard. Goals and KPIs should drive structured discussion and shared understanding of value with business stakeholders.

The Enterprise Architect's ultimate measure of success is not the number of documents produced — it is how coherently, efficiently, and strategically the organisation moves as a result of their work.